

ous blow to the image of the Gurjar leaders. When the official talks began in Jaipur, there was little sign that a peace deal was in the offing, but the arrival of Bainsla changed that. Raje publicly invited him for talks, knowing he was an ex-army officer who would be open to reason as long as she gave him the right signals and treated him with respect. She had help from the high command. BJP spokesperson Prakash Javadekar and general secretaries Ananth Kumar and Gopinath Munde were sent to Jaipur to help her negoti-

President's rule after Governor Pratibha Patil had airdashed to Delhi to brief the Centre about happenings and then summoned Raje next day for an update. That she eventually succeeded is as much a tribute to her own political maturity, as it is a slap in the face of those in her party who wanted the talks to fail, merely to weaken her position.

In fact, most of the crises she has faced since she took over as chief minister have been the work of her own party adversaries, at times fuelled by an ego clash between her and Jaswant.

Photographs by PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



REPRIEVE: Raje with Gurjar leaders led by Bainsla (centre) in Jaipur

ate and deal with the national media. The central leaders mobilised their Army contacts and found retired Colonel Atar Singh, a Gurjar himself, and known to Bainsla. Atar joined in as one of the mediators and was amongst those who persuaded Bainsla for talks. It was clear that the party top leadership had not left her to fight the battle alone. It also kept Congress at bay by warning against imposition of

He was extremely powerful and in power when she was pushed into the chief ministership. Four years later, the tables have turned. He is out of power and she has emerged stronger. That has only turned Jaswant more bitter. However, party president Rajnath Singh and veteran leaders L.K. Advani and Atal Bihari Vajpayee have stood by

her. Vajpayee, incidentally, is being blamed for the current turmoil as his granting OBC status to Jats opened this Pandora's box of demands for changes in reservation status. It was ironical that the Government's worst enemy was its own party. Five BJP MLAs offered to resign in protest.

For Raje, however, the victory could be short-lived. The BJP's Gurjar MLAs are still protesting against the agreement with Bainsla. They plan to meet in Pushkar on June 8 to decide the future course of action. Bainsla, being largely non-political, is satisfied with the agreement but other Gurjar leaders are frustrated at not being able to extract any mileage from the agitation. Their display of resentment is to show the community that even if Bainsla has agreed to withdraw the agitation, they plan to keep the issue alive.

In essence, what Raje has promised is that a three-member high powered committee headed by a retired high court judge will analyse the community's demands within the Government of India guidelines. Since 1977, no new caste has been added to the SC/ST category and despite a recommendation by Congress government in 1981, the Gadaria Lohars and the Banjaras have not been added to the list. This very recommendation had left out the Gurjars and 16 other castes as not being eligible for ST status. The guidelines under which the Gurjars claim will be reviewed will be based on conditions like primitiveness, backwardness, shyness of contact, distinctive culture and geographical isolation.

The state recommendation is followed by recommendations by the Registrar-General, Census and by the National Scheduled Tribe Commission before it is presented to the Union Cabinet which then has to present it before Parliament as a bill. It is notified once both the Houses pass it. The issue now is whether the committee will be able to do everything within the three-month deadline. It is not easy since there is a lack of data or research available about the Gurjar community's current living standards and status.

What can be a source of worry for Raje is that the Gurjar and Meena divide has got sharper, with the threat of caste violence still hovering over the